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Discuss how Government of India Acts of 1858 and 1861 reflect the British response to Revolt of 1857 - not just as a political crisis, but as an administrative reckoning. [38M]

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The Revolt of 1857 exposed ^{EIC's} British misgovernance in India which was seen as both political and administrative failure. In response to this revolt, Government introduced Government of India Act 1858 and 1861 to end Company's Rule with the beginning of Crown Rule ^{in India} and to initiate limited Indian participation in legislation so as to appease them.

British Response to the revolt by the introduction of Acts

(i) Beginning of Crown Rule in India

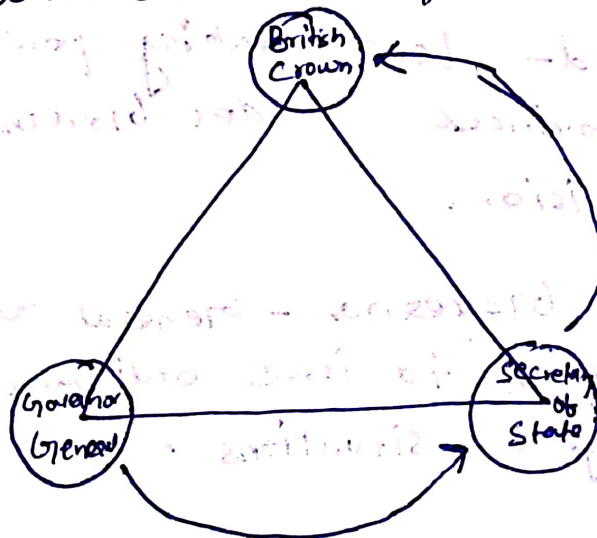
- End of company's Rule by introduction of Government of India Act 1858.
- Queen Victoria's proclamation

asserted 'British Paramountcy' with no further acquiring of states.

- British divided its territory into two parts - one, directly under British administration and other princely states set free.

(ii) Parliamentary Control over Indian Affairs

- 'Secretary of State for India', a new cabinet position created.
- He was assisted by a 15-member Council of India.
- Governor-General designated as Viceroy who was official representative of the crown.
- State responsibility, legal governance, ministerial accountability affirmed leading to legal-bureaucratic imperialism in India.



(iii) Deen Limited Indian Participation in Legislation

- The 1861 Act was an attempt to allow participation of Indians to prevent further rebellions.
- Governor General's Executive Council expanded to 12 additional legislative members, including some nominated Indians.
- First legal recognition of Indian such as Raja of Benaras, Maharaja of Patiala in law-making.

(iv) Decentralisation at Provincial level

- Legislative powers were restored to Bombay and Madras presidencies.
- Limited law making power of provinces under Governor's supervision.
- The Governor-General was empowered to issue ordinances in urgent situations.

(v)

Concept of separatism

- Inclusion of selected Indians in legislation sowed the seed of "Divide and Rule through selective Inclusion".
- This strategy was adopted ~~to~~ so as to prevent them from uniting against British power in India.

British realised that after revolt of 1857 that it would be possible to rule such vast Empire as India without making changes in internal structure of governance in India. So, they introduced Government of India Act 1858 and 1861 to address both political and administrative concerns to ensure loyalty from Indians and in consolidating British rule in India.